

Pet Care: Fireworks And Our Furry Friends [B2]

I fuochi d'artificio piacciono a tutti, ma non ai nostri amici a quattro zampe. La veterinaria ci consiglia come affrontare le feste più rumorose.

Loud celebrations might be **exhilarating** for humans, but most dogs, cats and other pets would much rather fast-forward to a quieter time of year. Sometimes, though, **fireworks** can be hard to escape — just look at New Year's Eve celebrations worldwide, Guy Fawkes Night in the UK, or Bastille Day in France. Dogs often become extremely anxious during these noisy celebrations, trembling, **howling** or even escaping in search of a safe refuge.

THE FALLAS

In Europe, the city that is most famous for its pyrotechnics is Valencia, Spain. Did you know that 24 per cent of the companies active in the pyrotechnic industry in Spain are based in Valencia? That's a lot of **fireworks**! The main pyrotechnic event in the Valencian calendar is the Fallas, held annually between 1 March and 19 March. Officially inaugurated on the last Sunday of February in Valencia city centre, the annual festival is a traditional celebration in commemoration of Saint Joseph, the patron saint of carpenters. Historically, carpenters would burn **surplus** materials on the day of St. Joseph (19 March) every year. But the festival has grown in scale. In 2016, the Fallas received UNESCO Intangible Cultural Heritage status.

LOUD BANGS

During the Fallas, on every street corner, you can find **towering** figures called ninots, made of flammable materials such as resin, fibreglass, **Styrofoam**, wood, papier-mâché and **plaster**. These often **portray** satirical messages, connected to **current affairs**. People will have an opportunity to admire the works of art before the ritual burning of the ninots during La Cremà, the final night of the Fallas. The Fallas in Valencia. You'll also hear the incessant sound of **firecrackers**, alongside daily **pyrotechnic displays**. Mascletàs (imagine

someone setting fire to a [clothesline](#) with [gunpowder pegged](#) to it) are scheduled daily for nineteen days [in a row](#). And those hoping for a [lie-in](#) can expect to be awakened by various despertà, essentially an explosive morning wake-up call by the falleros (the Fallas organisers) at the height of the festival. Oh, and not forgetting the [fireworks](#) or the [dusk-until-dawn](#) outdoor parties, of course. The event attracts more than a million tourists to the city; great for the economy, but not always so great for the residents. As you can imagine, most people either love it or hate it. It is not difficult to imagine that most dogs just hate it. People

Do You Have Problems With Your Cat's Behaviour? Let's Talk To A Feline Expert Anche i gatti hanno la propria personalità, e può capitare che abbiano anche i loro problemi. A New York, chi ha un gatto "difficile" si rivolge alla cat trainer Sharon Mear, esperta in psicologia felina. Chuck Rolando

CALM YOUR CANINE

So, whether you are planning a trip to Valencia with your dog during the Fallas, or you're just curious to find out how to help man's best friend get through never-ending [pyrotechnic displays](#), you are in the right place. To find out more, Speak Up spoke to London-born veterinary technician and anaesthesiologist Iris Rinn. Rinn is half-Scottish and half-Spanish and works at Finca Roja veterinary clinic in Valencia. She shared [coping](#) strategies that can help your dogs to feel calmer, despite the loud festivities surrounding them. First of all, she spoke about natural methods to promote a sense of safety at home. **Iris Rinn (Scottish accent):** The natural way would be [to] make a cave-type area in the house or wherever you're staying. It should be the place that's [farthest away](#) from the windows or the door. If you have a [carrier](#) or a [kennel](#) or a [cage](#) or something, or even if it's just like a [comfy](#) dog bed or something like that, you can have it in the corner so it's really dark and [cosy](#). Keep that room with the lights off and the [shutters](#) down. And you can keep the door [slightly ajar](#) so that they can go in and out but without having it completely open so all the sound goes in. With cats you can do something similar. It's as simple as a [cardboard](#) box and a T-shirt. You can put like a T-shirt over it so the neck makes like the entrance way. A young dog such as this can suffer with sudden noises and bright lights. Creating a

safe and sheltered place for your pet can make all the difference, says Iris Rinn.

PET NUTRITION

But often, creating safe areas is not enough. So giving your dog supplements can also be a good idea during this time, as Rinn explained. **Iris Rinn:** There are these natural supplements that you can give your animals, both for dogs and cats. You can either do pills or like a [syrup](#). The ones that I recommend are called Calmatonine. This has green tea and it has melatonin. It works really, really well. It helps calm them down. As it's natural, it's not like, "Oh, you give them a pill and they're fine", no. You have to give it to them for a long period of time, minimum a month. Personally, I actually use this at home with one of my dogs. She's a very [fearful](#) dog and it just works really well. She's just much calmer in the street. She doesn't react to dogs the same. It's really, really good. And as it's natural, you don't have to worry about [side effects](#).

TIME YOUR WALKS

Timing your dog walks during loud celebrations is essential to make the experience less stressful. In 2025, the Valencia Veterinary College launched the campaign "Pañuelo Verde, Paseo Tranquilo" ("Green Bandana, Calm Walk"), [whereby](#) dogs that were particularly sensitive to loud noises wore green bandanas. The idea was that the bandana should act as a reminder to [revellers](#) to [avoid setting off firecrackers](#) near the animal. Rinn told us more. **Iris Rinn:** You can also try and think of times where dogs can go out to the street where there's less [fireworks](#) and less people, 'cause there are certain times of the day where people are, I don't know, maybe eating or whatever, and you can use those times. This past Fallas, there was this movement where we were trying to make people conscientious of how stressful Fallas is for animals. It was like from such-and-such time to another such-and-such time, don't throw [fireworks](#) or [firecrackers](#). So that the dogs can have a couple of hours a day where they would have like a non-stressful walk. [Town Hall](#) gave out these green bandanas to give out to all people who

have pets who are scared of fires, or dogs mainly, obviously. So if you see a dog with the green bandana around their neck, you know that they are very, very [fearful](#) of loud noises or [firecrackers](#), all that. So you should be respectful and maintain your distance and try and not throw [firecrackers](#). Also really important, a lot of people, they're like, "Oh, I'm gonna take my dog everywhere." But I've seen a lot of people just [drag](#) them into [humongous crowds](#). It's like, "Why are you going to [put your animal through](#) that? It's not necessary, you know?"

GENTLE EXPOSURE

Helping dogs cope with these situations isn't just about managing the moment. It is, in fact, possible to make dogs more accustomed to loud noises. Rinn described a simple method that anyone can follow. **Iris Rinn:** You can also train your dog to get used to the noise, to get used to the sound by maybe buying [firecrackers](#), if you can, like very small ones. And taking [treats](#) out with you and then maybe throwing [firecrackers](#) at a distance. It would be good to have two people. One is with the dog and the other is throwing [firecrackers](#) at a distance. So it isn't very loud. And if you throw the firecracker and the dog doesn't react, that's great. [Pet](#) the dog, give it a treat. Don't excite it. And if it goes good, you can make the distance shorter, and throw another firecracker until you [reach the threshold](#). And if the dog starts to react, then you have to stop there and then go back with it again. Always end the training session on a positive note, that's really important.

EARLY TRAINING

It's important, however, to make sure that you [factor in](#) adequate time before the [fireworks](#) celebration to begin your dog training, as Rinn explained. **Iris Rinn:** This isn't something you should do a week before or a month before. It's something that you need to do with a lot of time in advance because it's not something that they're going to learn in five minutes. They need to get used to it with time. We at the clinic actually started making people conscientious in January, 'cause Fallas' party, basically,

the holiday, is from the 15 to the 19 of March, which is where people are [off school](#) and a lot of people actually get time off work and everything.

NATURAL METHODS

There are some artificial methods of managing dogs' natural fear response to loud noises, but Rinn recommended starting with natural methods. **Iris Rinn:** If we go to artificial management, then we start going into medications and sedatives and things like that, which are kind of like a [last resort](#) for those dogs who are very, very, very [fearful](#) and go into, like, [fight or flight](#) mode or worse, [freeze](#). I've had cases of dogs who wouldn't eat, they wouldn't... nothing. It was horrible! They'd just be trembling all over, they would do their business on themselves... Horrible! So if we can use all these management techniques first to help them get through it naturally, that would be best.

MORE TIPS

[Pet](#) owners can also introduce sounds similar to those that their pets are likely to hear during the celebration. However, the earlier, the better. **Iris Rinn:** When animals are young, like [puppies](#) and [kittens](#) and all that, when they're learning, their brain is open to learning new things and they're forming connections and all that. So it's really important to use this time to get them used to these things. A lot of people put [fireworks](#) on their TV while they're [chewing](#) on a toy or something, so they get used to the sound and all that.

Glossary

- **cosy** = accogliente
- **syrup** = sciroppo
- **avoid** = evitare
- **humongous** = enormi
- **crowds** = folle
- **Styrofoam** = polistirene espanso
- **portray** = rappresentare
- **kennel** = cuccia
- **revellers** = festaioli
- **put your animal through** = sottoporre a
- **factor in** = tenere in conto
- **fight or flight** = attacco o fuga
- **freeze** = restare paralizzato
- **whereby** = per cui
- **drag** = trascinare
- **Pet** = accarezzare
- **reach the threshold** = raggiungere la soglia
- **surplus** = eccedenza
- **lie-in** = rimanere a letto, dormire fino a tardi
- **comfy** = comodo
- **fearful** = paurosa
- **setting off** = far esplodere
- **kittens** = gattini
- **plaster** = gesso
- **Town Hall** = municipio
- **howling** = ululare
- **fireworks** = fuochi d'artificio
- **current affairs** = attualità
- **pyrotechnic displays** = spettacoli pirotecnici
- **gunpowder** = polvere da sparo
- **pegged** = fissare con mollette
- **in a row** = consecutivi
- **dusk-until-dawn** = dal tramonto all'alba

- **exhilarating** = esaltanti, emozionanti
- **firecrackers** = petardi
- **carrier** = trasportino
- **slightly ajar** = socchiusa
- **cardboard** = cartone
- **side effects** = effetti collaterali
- **treats** = premi
- **off school** = in vacanza
- **clothesline** = stendibiancheria
- **coping** = affrontare
- **cage** = gabbia
- **shutters** = persiane
- **last resort** = ultima risorsa
- **puppies** = cuccioli
- **chewing** = mordere
- **Loud** = rumorose
- **towering** = gigantesche
- **farthest away** = il più lontano possibile